

Giving | JERI FISCHER KRENTZ

Food drive replenishes pantries, sets record

Ninety-two tons of food – enough to last at least through spring – was collected during the recent Loaves & Fishes food drive in Mecklenburg County.

The 92 tons – that's 184,000 pounds – crushed the record 77.2 tons collected during last year's drive.

"I think people are realizing that we can't change the world, but we can do little things that really make a difference in our own communities," says Beverly Howard, Loaves & Fishes director.

"I also believe that people are aware that the need is high this year with the economy. People really want to help when they know the need is there."

Loaves & Fishes' 16 food pantries provide a week's worth of nutritious groceries to people in crisis.

Last year, 51,000 people visited for emergency help. This year, with the weak economy, staff members fear they'll see a steady increase in that number.

In fact, the agency broke a 27-year record by serving 6,400 people in January alone. The previous record was 4,500 in a single month.

For more information, call Loaves & Fishes at (704) 523-4333 or visit the Web site at www.loavesandfishes.org.

Disaster relief fund gives local grants

Through their joint disaster relief fund, United Way of Central Carolinas and Foundation for the Carolinas have awarded five grants worth more than \$123,000 to help with local needs resulting

FEDERALLY PROTECTED SPECIES



WENDY YANG - STAFF PHOTOS

Betty O'Leary feeds a great horned owl Thursday at the rehabilitation facility at the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville. The owl was found in a trash bin Thursday morning with a severe head injury.

Owl being treated after severe beating

Bird found in trash bin; chance of survival unknown

BY CRISTINA C. BREEN
Staff Writer

SHELBY — A great horned owl that had been trapped, beaten and left for dead in a plastic grocery bag in a trash bin clung to life Thursday evening at the Carolina Raptor Center.

Exams showed that the female bird — a new mother — had been caught in a metal leghold trap and suffered a concussion from being beaten with a bat or other hard object.

"She's not out of the woods. We don't know how much trauma she suffered," said rehabilitation assistant Betty O'Leary.

The owl was discovered about 9 a.m. Thursday by brothers Paul and Lee Allen, who heard a rustling in the trash bin outside an auto parts store where Lee Allen works. They expected to see a cat and were shocked to see the injured bird.

"When we got him out, he was groggy-looking, like he was exhausted," Lee Allen said. "He opened his eyes and moved his head. It was just unusual to see something like that."

He called the Cleveland County Humane Society, which took the bird to Gastonia where a volunteer from the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville picked it up. Experts there worked Thursday to save the owl from life-threatening head injuries and deep cuts on her toes.

The owl is believed to be a new mother, because of the "brood patch" on her neck and chest where downy feathers have come off to allow for direct skin-contact with her eggs or young.

Because most male owls help their mates raise their young, O'Leary said the babies may be able to survive without their mother.

"We have no idea where this bird was originally trapped, so there's no way of finding this nest," she said.

If the owl survives, O'Leary said it will spend about two months recovering at the Raptor Center before being re-released in Cleveland County.

The brown-feathered bird has a body about the size of a foot-

ball, a head the size of a cantaloupe, and feet and claws the size of a child's hand. It was lying in an incubator Thursday afternoon after having its wounds cleaned and receiving medications and food orally and through injection.

Owls are common birds of prey in the Carolinas but are federally protected. Those who hurt or kill owls or other birds protected under the Migratory Bird Treaty Act can be fined up to \$5,000.

Cleveland County Humane Society President Marguerite Mebane said she planned to contact law enforcement authorities Thursday evening.

People who hurt or kill predatory birds such as owls usually do so because the birds are eating domestic animals such as chickens or small dogs or cats, Mebane said. A better solution, she said, is to build a chicken coop or keep small pets in dog houses or enclosed buildings.

Cristina Breen: (704) 868-7744;
cbreen@charlotteobserver.com.